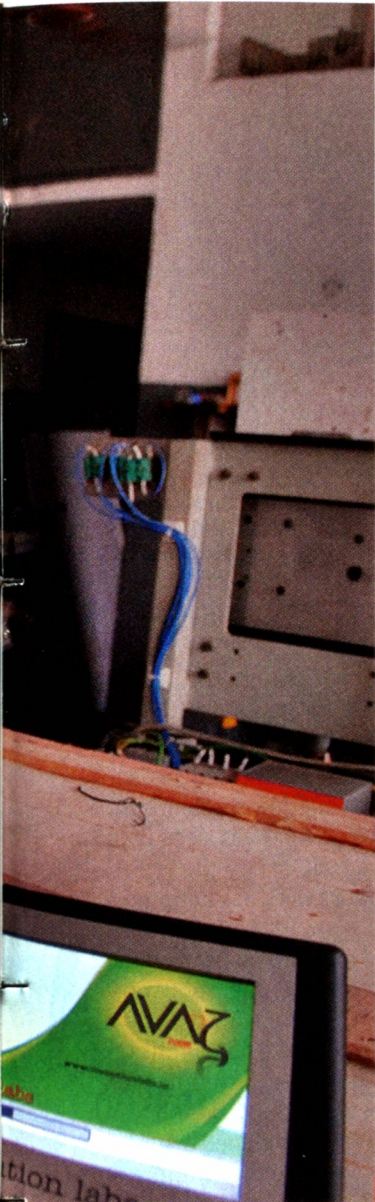




**NARAYANAN
WITH THE
AVAZ DEVICE**

Rohit's school, Vidya Sagar, to develop a commercially viable voice output communication aid. They were introduced to Vidya Sagar by one of their professors at IIT-Madras, who had asked them to visit the spastic society so that they could understand the requirement of a product that could help children with cerebral palsy. The goal was to come up with a product that will help these children convey virtually any thought in their mind. This was to be a one-of-its-kind product in the Indian market, with the products available abroad being priced at over Rs 3 lakh. "The idea was to not let non-verbal children feel incompetent," says Chandrasekaran who loves to read about business models that have an impact on the society and has a deep interest in social entrepreneurship. In 2007, Chandrasekaran and Narayanan along with two other from their batch of 2003—Adib Ibrahim and Preetham

received a grant of Rs 10 lakh under the Technopreneur Promotion Programme from the Union Ministry of Science & Technology to develop an augmentative and alternative communication device with dynamic message generation and speech synthesis for children with cerebral palsy. Invention Labs continuously interacted with Vidya Sagar's teachers and students to validate the usability and impact of the prototypes of the device. After a couple of rounds of prototyping and working on the feedback from children and teachers, the design was finalised, and the beta version of the device went into production. Finally, Avaz was launched in February this year. Since then, Avaz has been deployed at two schools in Chennai and five schools across Mumbai, Kolkata and Bangalore.

This battery-operated device is intuitive and user-friendly. The sentences are constructed using visual or auditory scanning. In response to this scanning, the software presents options based on frequency of occurrence. Once the sentence is created, it is spoken out by the speech synthesiser. Commonly used sentences are stored for quick retrieval. Not only does it enable full freedom of expression but it also allows independent operation. It's portable and can be mounted on a wheelchair.

The innovator duo now plans to leverage the many features of Avaz to extend its use to a classroom environment, where children could be taught by using it. Special-purpose applications could also be built to work in specific areas to help such children take up gainful employment later. Avaz could also be linked to a computer or a mobile phone. "I want Avaz to reach each and every child who needs it," says Chandrasekaran. And then many more Rohits can use this machine to voice their emotions. ■

NOT ONLY DOES THIS DEVICE ENABLE CHILDREN TO EXPRESS THEMSELVES BUT IT ALSO ALLOWS INDEPENDENT OPERATION.

first time in his life. "Using Avaz, I can now say anything I want. I can go out on my own and talk to people. It makes me happy and confident," says Rohit.

It all began in May 2008 when two IIT-Madras alumni Aswin Chandrasekaran, 28, and Ajit Narayanan, 28, began engaging with

K. Shivanna—started a company called Invention Labs to create products designed with Indian realities in mind. It was supposed to be an extension of the philosophies they shared that technology is global but inventions are local.

In February 2009, Narayanan

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